

Interdisciplinary Digital Art Educational Talk

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Interdisciplinary Digital Art class demonstration. Photo by Arnold Koroshegyi.

Abstract

My presentation highlights projects implemented in my Interdisciplinary Digital Art course at the University of Toronto Scarborough. These projects successfully encourage students to explore new technologies critically and creatively; they introduce them to practical skills and spark important reflections on the cultural, ethical, and social implications of ubiquitous digital systems. Among the technologies addressed: networking, data mining, surveillance, information aesthetics, social media culture, and locative media.

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1 Introduction

My approach to teaching encourages students to become active self-media creators, critical collectors of aesthetic information and participants in global digital culture. Blending creative experimentation with technological aptitude, my pedagogical framework aims to provide students with the tools they need to engage critically with

evolving media environments while developing interdisciplinary approaches to artmaking.

To support this, I design innovative curricula that incorporate graphic and experimental art strategies and create projects for students informed by emerging technologies. By framing assignments around current innovations, students connect theoretical concepts to experiential learning. The rapid pace of change in digital media motivates me to continuously re-evaluate both the learning experiences I create for students and my own art practice.

2 Implementation

An example of this interdisciplinary and experimentation curriculum I recently designed is the Interdisciplinary Digital Art (VPSC70H3) course, a studio-based class that is an exploration of media-based arts which provides students with hands-on production experience and introduces them to the critical, theoretical, and historical questions around "new" technologies. The fundamental concepts of Digital Art and New Media Studio practice are examined including integration, immersion, interface, interactivity, narrativity, hypermedia, non-linearity, and connectivity.

In this course, students are expected to develop basic technical and conceptual skills for production and critical engagement in the areas of electronic arts, intermedia practice, computer applications and media culture. As this unique interdisciplinary approach to art-making involves multiple disciplines and technologies, there must be significant attention in terms of assistance and resources provided to students. With the aid of various classroom support technologists and instructors, students can develop, problem solve and create their experiential-based projects.

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My approach to teaching Interdisciplinary Digital Art involves implementing innovative strategies to explore contemporary art that is created, altered, or transmitted using new forms of media technology. I also consider how new media art is rapidly evolving in tandem with advancing new technologies. As such, the projects assigned in class are designed to encourage students to creatively examine a wide range of new technologies while also eliciting an important reflection on the ubiquitous information technologies that are radically transforming our culture.

Among the many varied new technologies that are offering artists new opportunities for discovery I address in class are networking, WiFi, GPS, computing, data mining, RFID, surveillance, information technologies, mapping, information aesthetics, social media culture and locative media. Students produce works across a wide range of areas including 2D/3D imaging, public art, interactivity, time-based production, sound installation, digital image processing and interactive media-installation.

3 Learning Objectives

Some of the unique technical training and skills covered include:

- Exploration of media-based arts that provides students with hands-on production experience and introduces them to the critical, theoretical, and historical questions of "new" digital art practices.
- Develop basic technical and conceptual skills for production and critical engagement in the areas of electronic arts, inter-media practice, computer applications and media culture.
- Work independently, hone research strategies and complete a capstone project.

General Digital Practice Topics Covered:

- In-depth investigation of the theory and practice of contemporary digital art, including the fundamental concepts of New Media and Digital Art.
- Introduction to Locative Media, specifically digital projects that respond to data or communication technologies that refer to a particular site or location.
- Development of research and conceptual creative practices. Here, students generate art works around assignment prompts that encourage an inter-disciplinary art process.
- From research and conceptual creative development through prototyping and planning to final presentation, projects are created that range from two-dimensional image-based collages, video, sound, programming, extended reality, multimedia installations and three-dimensional construction. Classes are comprised of lectures, workshops, readings, class discussions and critiques.

4 Critical and Conceptual Engagement:

- Digital Art as an Integrated Disciplinary Practice: The integration of media, and the use of technology to produce work that is cross-disciplinary, and that engages with the other areas of study within the visual arts.
- Technological Consequences: The probing and examination of the environmental and ecological impact of technological practices.

- Interdisciplinary fluidity: An exploration of where the boundaries of *digital art* are particularly *fluid*, and how digital art practices are increasingly merging with science and technology.

5 Conclusion and Future Work

My goal in developing the Interdisciplinary Digital Art curriculum is to provide students with multiple ways to engage with class material, to offer a varied representation of curricular concepts and to create an environment where students can explore new, unusual methods of art production.

Future projects include an exciting collaboration with the Acceleration Consortium, a University of Toronto-based group of academics, and industry experts using Artificial Intelligence to develop sustainable materials. I have been involved in the development of a cooperative workshop to bring together students and Acceleration Consortium members to create art projects around the concept of data visualization based on scientific research practices. This initiative will provide Acceleration Consortium scientists with a platform to discuss their research and methodologies with students who will then imagine, explore, and visually experiment with the hidden structures beneath and beyond the numbers, to find artistic avenues to represent various forms of data.

Once completed, the art works will be presented to the Acceleration Consortium research teams for response and discussion, then exhibited publicly and online. In this symbiotic relationship between art and science, art is leveraged as a knowledge mobilization mechanism; it transforms and inspires students' creative practices while offering researchers a novel way to interpret and disseminate their scientific endeavours.

This original pedagogical collaboration is currently in development and will be conducted in the spring of 2026.

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